

The politics of spatial inequality

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March 2026



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■



Grantham
Research Institute
on Climate Change
and the Environment



PUBLIC
OPINION
ANALYTICS
LAB

Who I Am as a Researcher

*I use **micro-level quantitative data** and **design-based causal inference methods** to study **political behaviour** in the context of **spatial inequality** and **climate change**.*

Data

- Administrative micro-data
- Social media data
- Political communication

Methods

- Generative AI & NLP
- Design-based causal inference
- Survey & field experiments

Substantive Interests

- Climate politics
- Party competition
- Right-wing populism

Research Agenda

Distributional conflict

Climate change and the populist right

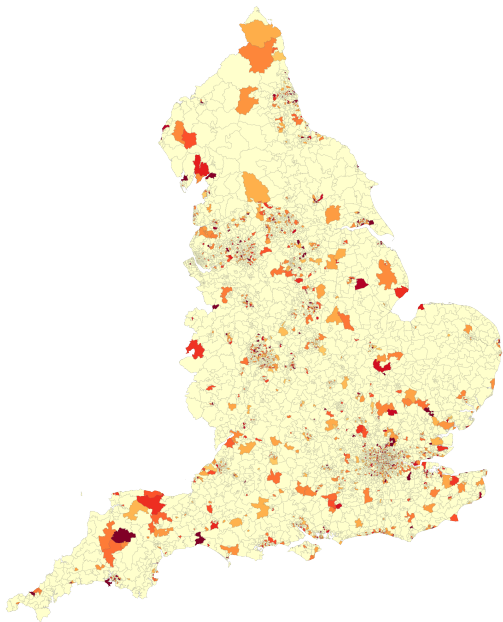
Party Competition

Research Agenda

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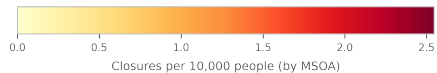
Climate change and the populist right

Party Competition



1,726

GP practice closures
in England, 2013–2023



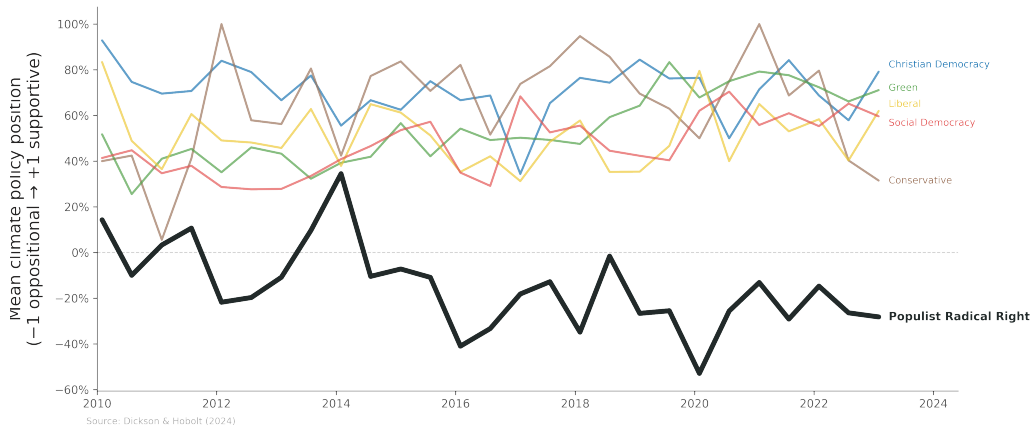
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Party Competition

Populist Radical Right Parties Reject the Mainstream Consensus across Europe Climate Change Policies



Research Agenda

Distributional conflict

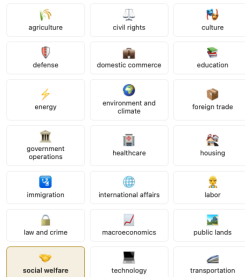
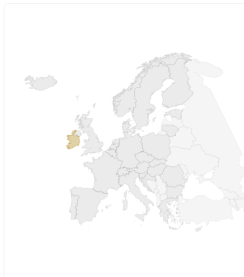
Climate change and the populist right

Party Competition

Beta — not yet reliable. Data and availability may change.

Browse & search press releases

~500k party press releases across 30 countries. Filter, search, and download.



..... Search all columns... Ireland All parties

social welfare 03/11/2026 03/11/2026 Apply

Show 10 per page Sort by Date Descending Download CSV (max 1,000)

583,119 press releases indexed
15,724 results

Country	Date	Party	Issue	Title	
Ireland	2026-02-18	Green Party	social welfare	O'Gorman calls on Minister to explain to schools why their SNA allocations are being cut	Show text
Ireland	2026-	Green	social	GREENS CALL FOR PROTECTION OF NIGHT-TIME	Show

A Closer Look

Green Backlash: Energy Prices, Blame Attribution, and the Populist Right

Your latest energy bill

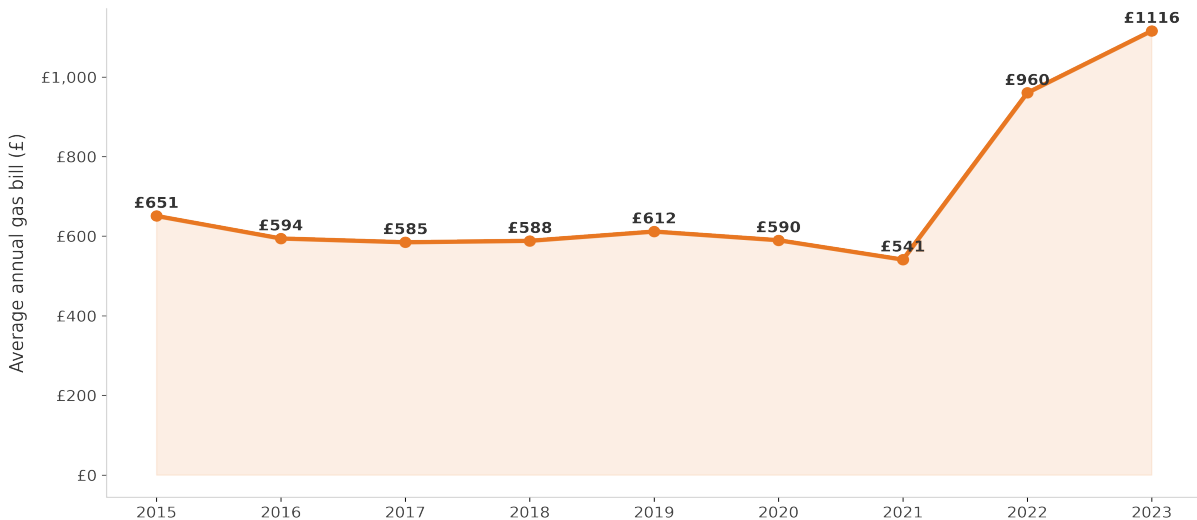
Hi Jacob

Your latest energy bill is ready.
See you can see what you've
used and how much between 1
and 21



Average UK Household Gas Bill

UK average annual gas bill including standing charge, weighted by number of meters



Source: OFGEM / BEIS regional gas price data, linked to LSOA meter counts

Research Question

What are the political effects of rising household energy bills?

Expectations

Rising Household Energy Bills. . .

- **Supply:**
 - ↔ PRR communication increasingly frames rising bills as a consequence of Net Zero
- **Demand:**
 - ↔ Households most exposed increase demand for PRR parties
 - ↔ Households most exposed decrease demand for climate policy

Data

EPC Ratings

DLUHC Open Data

27m certificates

Pre-2021 efficiency
ratings by LSOA

Understanding Society

UKHLS Annual Panel

~30,000 households

13 waves, 2009–2023

British Election Study

Continuous Online Panel

30 waves

Vote intention &
climate attitudes

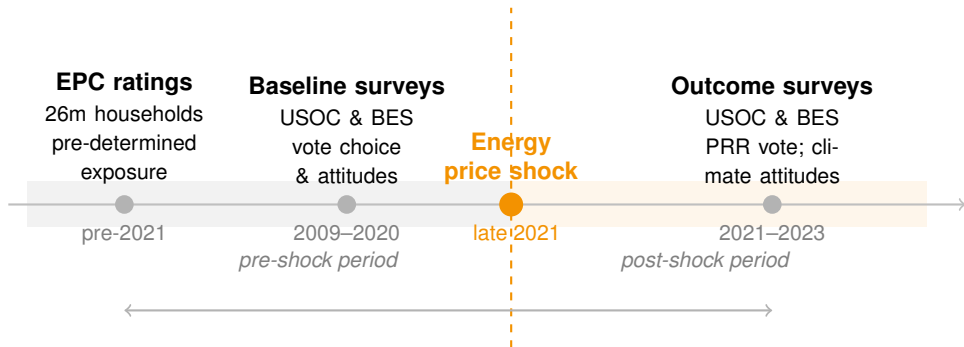
Party Communication

*Press releases &
YouTube*

8,669 documents

6 parties, 2019–2026

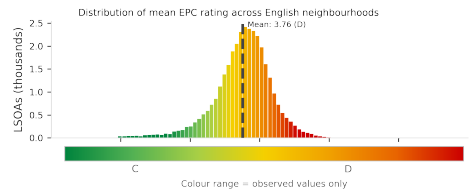
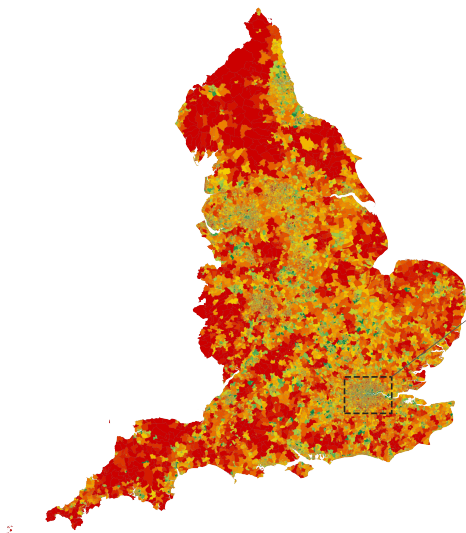
Research Design: a natural experiment



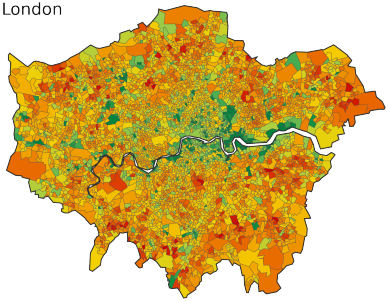
DiD & Event Studies: comparing high vs. low EPC vulnerability areas before and after 2021

Findings

- Energy price shocks fall hardest on communities with older, less efficient housing — creating a **geography of vulnerability**



London



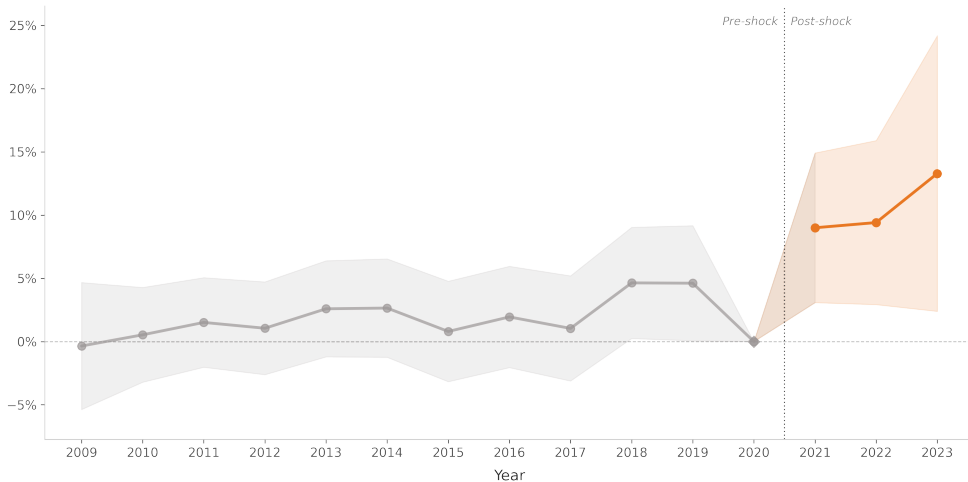
Source: Energy Performance Certificates (pre-2021), ONS LSOA boundaries

Findings

- Energy price shocks fall hardest on communities with older, less efficient housing — creating a **geography of vulnerability**
- Households in energy-inefficient areas paid **disproportionately more** after the 2021 price shock

Households in Neighbourhoods with higher EPC ratings experienced larger increases in reported gas bills

Effect of high EPC rating on reported annual gas bill (%) — economic controls



Note: reference period $t = -1$. Shaded bands = 95% CI. Dotted line = shock onset.
Source: Understanding Society, waves 1-14 (2009-2023).

Findings

- Energy price shocks fall hardest on communities with older, less efficient housing — creating a **geography of vulnerability**
- Households in energy-inefficient areas paid **disproportionately more** after the 2021 price shock
- While mainstream parties blamed Russia and global markets, PRR parties uniquely blamed **Net Zero** — turning energy bills into a weapon against climate policy

LIVE

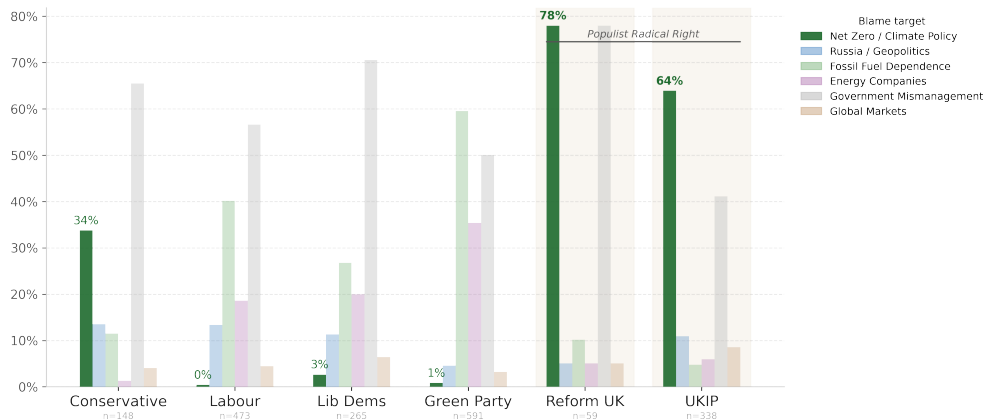
GREEN COSTS BLAMED FOR RISING ENERGY BILLS

Energy bosses warn green costs to push bills up even as gas prices fall

GBNEWS.COM

Populist Radical Right Parties uniquely blame Net Zero policy for rising energy bills

Share of energy-relevant communications attributing blame to each target (post Feb 2022)



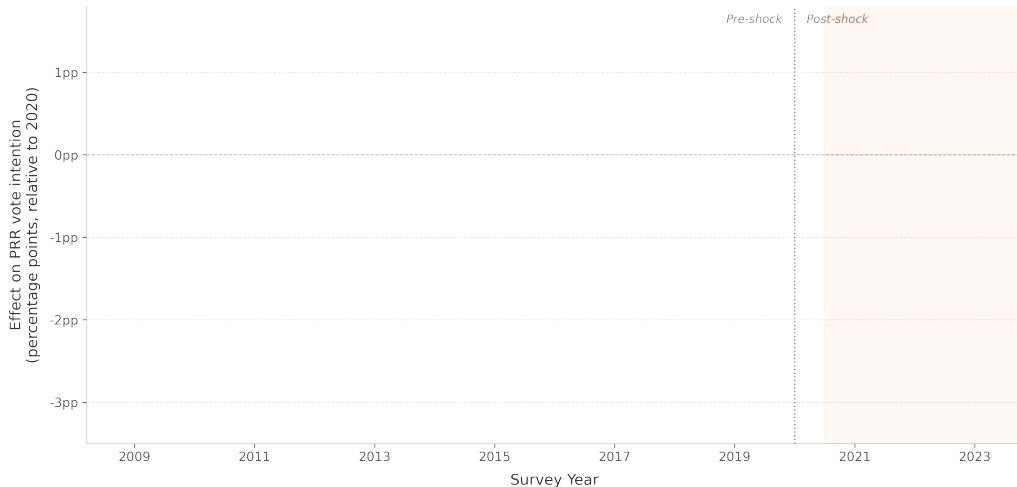
Note: A single communication can cite multiple blame targets.

Source: LLM annotations of YouTube Videos and Party Press Releases.

Findings

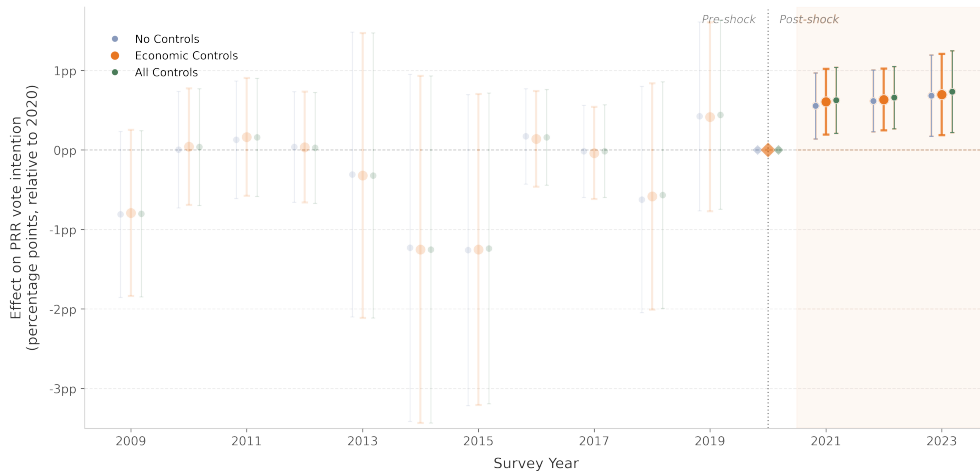
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- Energy-vulnerable communities became significantly more likely to **support PRR parties** after the 2021 shock

Event Study Results: Intention to Vote for a Populist Radical Right (PRR) Party (UKIP/Reform UK)



Energy-inefficient areas increasingly backed Populist Radical Right parties after the 2021 price shock

Effect of high EPC rating on PRR vote intention (percentage points) — three model specifications

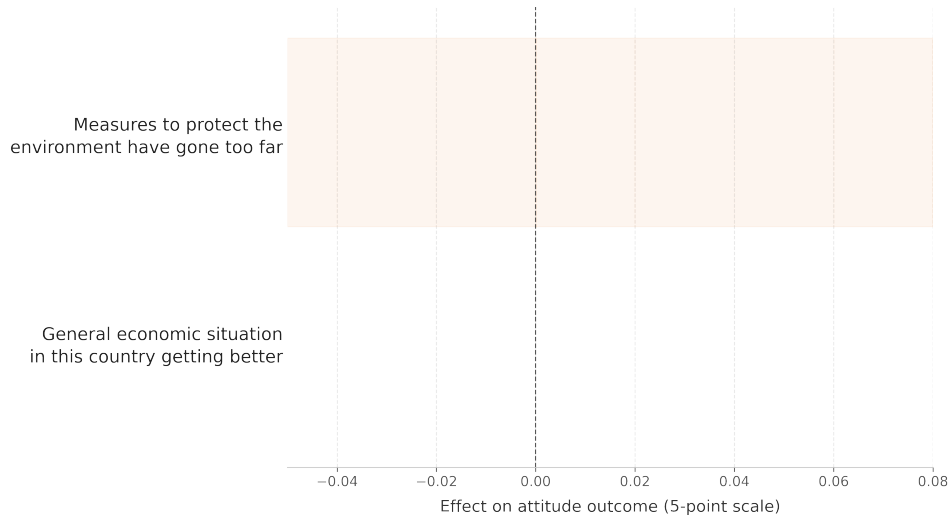


Note: reference period 2020. Bars = 95% CI. Dotted line = onset of 2021-22 energy price shock.
Source: Understanding Society (USOC), waves 1-14.

Findings

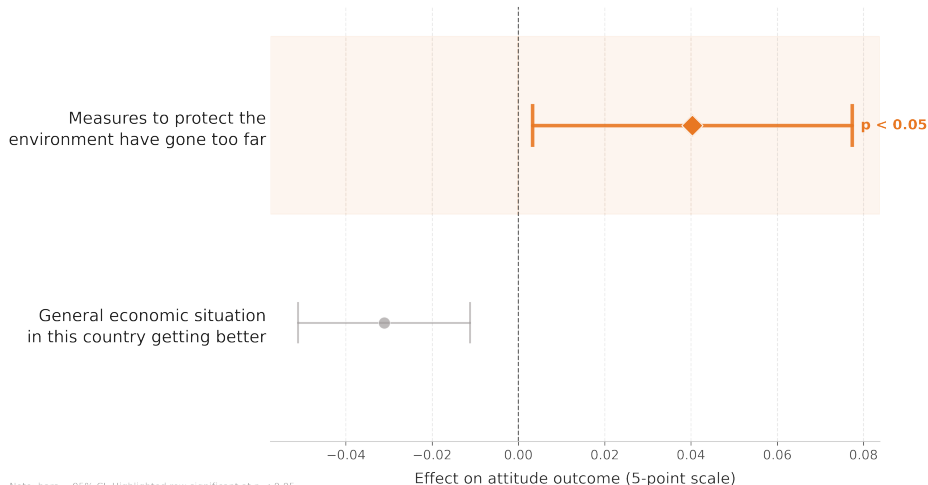
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- Energy-vulnerable communities became significantly more likely to **support PRR parties** after the 2021 shock
- The mechanism: rising bills **eroded support for environmental protection** and the green transition

Coefficient Plot Results: Attitudes about the Environment and Economy



Households most exposed to the energy price shock reduced support for measures to protect the environment

Effect of high EPC rating $\times$ post-2021 on BES attitude outcomes — TWFE difference-in-differences



Note: bars = 95% CI. Highlighted row significant at $p < 0.05$.
Source: British Election Study panel (waves 1–30).

Implications: Energy Prices & Climate Policy Support



- The burden of rising energy prices is spatially unequal — falling hardest on communities with the least efficient housing

Implications: Energy Prices & Climate Policy Support



- The burden of rising energy prices is spatially unequal — falling hardest on communities with the least efficient housing
- PRR parties exploit this concentrated hardship as evidence of elite betrayal, eroding support for the green transition
- Protecting the most exposed through targeted relief — and communicating it clearly — is essential to sustaining climate policy consensus

Grants & Future Projects

Ongoing and Future Projects

Energy Bills & Green Backlash - 2025-2027

British Academy/Leverhulme Trust

- Do rising energy bills erode support for climate policy and boost climate-sceptic parties?
- Presented at Oxford, Zurich, Humboldt, LSE, Manchester and EPSA/EPOP conferences

Ongoing and Future Projects

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Driving Restrictions, Co-Benefits, and Public Support for Climate Policy - 2026-2028

LSE Global School of Sustainability Research Fund

- Does effective communication of positive co-benefits (health, education, safety) raise support for ULEZ and Low Traffic Neighbourhoods?

↪ Proof of Concept for: ESRC / ERC

Contribution to the Bennett School

AI & Computational Social Science

Research

News access & bias
in generative AI

Political text
analysis at scale

Models & Tools

Fine-tuned LLMs
on Hugging Face

NLP pipelines for
political communication

Teaching

Workshops/courses on
Generative AI/LLMs

Causal Inference methods

Substantive Contributions

Climate Politics

Green transition costs
and public resistance

Energy prices &
electoral backlash

Party Competition

How parties frame
distributional conflict

Elite cues &
policy compliance

Right-Wing Populism

Spatial inequality
as political weapon

PRR accommodation
and electoral costs

Multidisciplinary Collaboration

I bring:

- **Lancet Countdown on Health and Climate Change:** annual contributor; bridges climate science, public health, and policy
- **Public Opinion Analytics Lab:** political consultancy working with pollsters and parties on best methods for measuring public opinion
- **Annual Climate and Political Behaviour Workshop** Brings together political scientists and economists to study climate politics

At Cambridge:

- **ai@cam:** research on news access and political bias in generative AI — directly relevant to the new M.Phil in Digital Policy (Oct 2026)
- **Energy Interdisciplinary Research Centre:** political demand-side analysis to complement Cambridge's energy systems and sustainability research
- **Cambridge Institute for Sustainability Leadership:** policy engagement via *Driving Restrictions, Co-Benefits, and Public Support for Climate Policy*

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Public Engagement and Media Coverage



- *The Economist, The Guardian, New Statesman, Forbes, El País, Internazionale*
- UN General Assembly Report A/80/138 — cited on inequality and right-wing populism

Zach Dickson

**The Politics of Spatial
Inequality**



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